

can be made from eggplant leaves. The mashed fruit can also be applied to sunburn.

Research German research (published in 1975) indicates that eggplant helps to prevent the accumulation of fatty deposits within arteries.

Caution Eggplant leaves are toxic and should only be used externally.

Solanum tuberosum (Solanaceae) Potato

Description Perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has branching stems with compound leaves, white or purple flowers, green berries, and swollen tubers (potatoes).



Potato can be helpful in relieving the painful symptoms of a gastric ulcer.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Chile, Bolivia, and Peru, the potato plant with its many varieties is cultivated around the world. The tuber is normally unearthed from autumn to early spring.

Part Used Tuber.

Constituents Potato contains starch, large amounts of vitamins A, B₁, B₂, C, and K, minerals (especially potassium), and very small quantities of atropine alkaloids. One property of these alkaloids is the reduction of digestive secretions, including acids produced in the stomach.

History & Folklore Many different potato species and varieties were cultivated by the Quechua and Aymara peoples of the central Andes. In the early 16th century, the potato was introduced into Europe by Spanish voyagers returning from the New World. It was not until the 18th century that the potato became a staple ingredient in the European diet.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Taken in moderation, potato juice can be helpful in the treatment of peptic ulcers, bringing relief from

pain and acidity. The juice or the mashed pulp may be used externally to soothe painful joints, headache, backache, skin rashes, and hemorrhoids. Potato skins are used in India to treat swollen gums and to heal burns.

Related Species The root of the Brazilian *S. insidiosum* is used as a diuretic and stomach-supporting remedy.

Cautions All parts of the plant except the tuber are poisonous. Excessive doses of potato juice are toxic. Do not drink the juice of more than one large potato per day.

Solidago virgaurea (Asteraceae) Goldenrod

Description Perennial plant growing to 28 in (70 cm). Has toothed leaves and branched spikes of golden-yellow flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe and Asia and naturalized in North America, goldenrod prefers open areas and hillsides. It is gathered in summer while in flower.

Parts Used Aerial parts.



Goldenrod is a valuable remedy for urethritis, nephritis, cystitis, and other ailments of the urinary tract.

Constituents Goldenrod contains saponins, diterpenes, phenolic glucosides, acetylenes, cinnamates, flavonoids, tannins, hydroxybenzoates, and inulin. The saponins are antifungal.

History & Folklore The herbalist John Gerard commented wryly in 1597 that "goldenrod has in times past been had in greater estimation and regard than in these days: for within my remembrance, I have known the dry herb which came from beyond the seas, sold ... for half a crown an ounce. But since it was found in Hampstead wood [London] ... no man will give half a crown for an hundredweight of it: which plainly setteth forth our inconstancy and sudden mutability, esteeming no longer of any thing (how precious soever it may be) than whilst it is strange and rare." Four hundred years on, one can only agree.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Antioxidant, diuretic, and astringent, goldenrod is a valuable remedy for urinary tract disorders. It is used both for serious ailments such as nephritis, and for more common problems like cystitis. The herb also has a reputation for helping to flush out kidney and bladder stones. Goldenrod's saponins act specifically against the *Candida* fungus, the cause of vaginal yeast infection and oral thrush. The herb can also be taken for conditions such as sore throats, chronic nasal congestion, and diarrhea. Due to its mild action, goldenrod is used to treat gastroenteritis in children. Externally, it may be used as a mouthwash or douche for thrush.

Related Species Various *Solidago* species are used medicinally in North America. Several species, including Canadian goldenrod (*S. canadensis*), have been taken to relieve colds, fevers, and chest pain. Sweet-scented goldenrod (*S. odora*) was listed as a stimulant, carminative, and diaphoretic (sweat-inducer) in the U.S. *Pharmacopoeia* from 1820 to 1882.

Self-help Uses Allergic rhinitis with congestion, p. 300; Urinary infections, p. 314.

Sorbus aucuparia (Rosaceae) Eastern Mountain Ash

Description Deciduous tree growing to 12 m (39 ft). Has reddish bark, compound leaves, clusters of small white flowers, and clusters of round red-orange fruit (berries). Also known as Rowan.

Habitat & Cultivation Mountain ash grows in woodlands throughout the Northern Hemisphere. It is also cultivated as an ornamental tree.

Part Used Fruit.

Constituents The fruit contains tannins, sorbitol, malic and sorbic acids, sugars, and vitamin C. The seeds contain cyanogenic glycosides, which, in a reaction upon